

MUSIC FOR MEDITATION AND HEALING

R_x Saptha Swaras



LET there be silence, briefly. Welcome to the Nada Mantapa. The first strains rise slowly, softly, stirring the heart. Also slowly but surely, the listener's awareness of the body begins to recede. Eventually, "body consciousness vanishes and with that, affliction ceases to be experienced and ceases to exist."

This, according to Sri Ganapati Sachchidananda Swamiji, the guiding force of the Avadhootha Datta Peetham in Mysore, forms the basis of healing through music and meditation. Sri Swamiji should know because he is the creator of the concept of fusing music and medication to obtain a healing tool both for the mind and the body.

There are riders to this definition. For healing through music and meditation, the person producing the notes has to possess certain qualities. He or she should be able to attain high levels of concentration or 'Ekagratha,' have a good grasp of ashta siddhis, Raga Ragini Vidya and astronomy, according to Poojya Sri Swamiji. Even the listener has to possess the ability to concentrate.

An accomplished musician and composer himself, Sri Swamiji has evolved his method of 'Nada chikitsa' or healing through music over the years, adding a new dimension to the appeal of music to a person. While one generally hears music that prompts one to move the body, appeals to the intellect, is replete with grace or touches the heart, Sri Swamiji is able to invoke musical strains that uplift the soul.

This quality enables Poojya Swamiji's music to encompass the listener and drive the awareness of bodily or mental ailments gradually away so effectively. In the long run, the sublime music erases the very existence of the ailment.

What makes the music sublime is the divine element that Sri Swamiji infuses into it. Through faith and his distinctive music, he is able to "attune man to God" and facilitate rapport between the two. The efficacy of this kind of music derives from the same five elements earth, water, air, fire and ether or, in short, from life itself. The characteristic qualities of these five elements invoked individually or in various combinations through musical vibrations are able to tackle specific conditions of the body and mind. Nada chikitsa also involves matching the

rhythm of the body with the rhythms of Nature. Bodily functions like pulse-beat, heart-beat, expansion and contraction of the lungs as we breathe follow a set rhythm. When matching rhythms are produced on musical instruments like the veena, the vibrations converge and exert a healing effect on the body.

Poojya Swamiji did not plunge into the application of music to therapeutic purposes as soon as he discovered the potential as early as in the 1960s. He spent two decades conducting research into effects of different forms of music on the 72,000 'yoga nadis' or nerve centres in the human body and only then, he launched on his mission across the globe to spread awareness of the health benefits from music. Still, Sri Swamiji points out, music does not replace medicine but can enhance its potency.

The time honoured Indian musical instrument, the veena naturally is Poojya Swamiji's favourite but he is equally accomplished in playing a modern instrument like a synthesizer which can reproduce the sounds of over one thousand instruments! He composes and sings bhajans in several languages.

Appropriately, the Nada Mantapa on the Datta Peetham complex is a true indicator of Sri Swamiji's passion for music and his intense desire to use the art as a tool of healing. The Nada Mantapa, also known as the Raga Ragini Samudaya Bhavana possesses very sophisticated acoustic qualities. It can hold five thousand people. Inside it is a shrine devoted to Saptha Swara Devathas.

